

Spanish Golden Age

The 17th century is often called the Spanish Golden Age, when the arts and literature flourished. Initially, Mannerism predominated, but soon artists began using rich colour and chiaroscuro and tenebrism to create a sense of drama.

Velázquez was the leading painter of the age, but others, such as Francisco de Zurbarán (1598–1664), were also highly admired. After spending time in Italy, José de Ribera (1591–1652) was particularly influenced by Caravaggio and took ideas of tenebrism back to Spain. Zurbarán also expressed strong chiaroscuro effects in religious paintings that include few background details and intense light and shade effects. Fray Juan Sánchez-Cotán (1560–1627) painted *bodegóns*, or still lifes, that are striking in their treatment of light, and Bartolomé Esteban Murillo (1617–82) also painted luminous effects in his religious works and paintings of contemporary women and children. Claudio Coello (c.1642–93) had a colourful, dramatic and dynamic style, influenced by both Velázquez and Titian.



Velázquez, *Pope Innocent X*, 1650